

THINGS WE NEVER SAID

Author: Sophie Laurent

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CHAPTER ONE

The Funeral

Sophie saw Daniel before he saw her.

He stood beneath the oldest tree in the cemetery, hands inside the pockets of his coat.

Eleven years.

She had spent eleven years trying not to remember what his face looked like.

She had failed.

Daniel looked older.

Of course he did.

So did she.

But there was something about his eyes that hadn't changed.

She looked away.

Her father's funeral was not the place for old memories.

People gathered around the grave.

Relatives.

Friends.

Neighbors.

People Sophie barely knew.

Everyone spoke softly.

Everyone said the same things.

"He lived a good life."

"He'll be missed."

"He was a wonderful man."

Sophie listened.

She didn't know whether she believed any of it.

Her father had been complicated.

So had their relationship.

She hadn't spoken to him properly in five years.

Now he was gone.

And there was no possibility of fixing that.

When the funeral ended, people slowly left.

Sophie remained.

Daniel remained too.

Eventually, he walked toward her.

"Hi."

She looked at him.

"Hi."

Eleven years.

One word.

It felt ridiculous.

"How are you?"

"Fine."

He nodded.

"Me too."

Neither of them smiled.

Daniel reached into his coat.

"I found something."

He handed her an envelope.

She recognized the handwriting immediately.

Their father's.

Sophie stared at it.

"What is this?"

"He left it for us."

"Us?"

Daniel nodded.

"Both of us."

She opened it.

Inside was a photograph.

Two teenagers stood beside a river.

Sophie remembered the day.

She remembered Daniel making her laugh.

She remembered their father's car waiting in the distance.

She remembered leaving that evening.

She had spent eleven years telling herself she knew why.

She turned the photograph over.

There was writing on the back.

You both know why she left.

Sophie's hands went cold.

She looked at Daniel.

He wasn't surprised.

"You knew?"

He looked toward their father's grave.

"I knew there was more to the story."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"Because you didn't want to hear it."

Sophie stared at him.

"I waited eleven years."

Daniel looked at her.

"So did I."

The wind moved through the trees.

Sophie looked down at the photograph again.

For the first time, she wondered whether the memory she had spent eleven years protecting was actually a lie.

And if it was—

she wasn't sure she wanted to know the truth.